Forest Society and Colonialism

The big idea

Forests give us wood, fruit, medicines, fodder and a home to millions of forest dwellers. Under colonial rule, forests across India and Indonesia (Java) were cut down on a huge scale and forest people lost their traditional rights. This chapter shows **why** deforestation happened, **how** commercial forestry changed lives, and **how** people resisted.

DEFORESTATION

Deforestation means the disappearance of forests. Between **1880 and 1920**, cultivated area in India rose by about **6.7 million hectares**, much of it carved out of forests.

Why deforestation?

1. **Land to be improved:** In 1600 about one-sixth of India was under cultivation; by 1980 it was about half. The British encouraged growing **commercial crops** like jute, sugar, wheat and cotton to feed Europe's growing population and supply raw material for industry. They also saw forests as "unproductive wilderness".
2. **Sleepers on the tracks:** By the early 19th century, **oak forests in England** were disappearing, creating a shortage of timber for the **Royal Navy**. Search parties went to India. From the 1850s, the spread of **railways** created a new demand: wooden **sleepers** to hold the tracks, and wood to fuel locomotives. Each mile of track needed **1,760 to 2,000 sleepers**. By 1890, about 25,500 km of track had been laid; by 1946, over 7,65,000 km.

3. **Plantations:** large areas of natural forest were cleared to make way for **tea, coffee and rubber** plantations, given to Europeans at cheap rates.

Commercial forestry

The British were worried that local people and traders would destroy forests. They invited a German expert, **Dietrich Brandis**, who became the first **Inspector General of Forests in India**. He set up:

- the **Indian Forest Service** in **1864**,
- the **Indian Forest Act** of **1865**,
- the **Imperial Forest Research Institute at Dehradun** in **1906**, which taught "**scientific forestry**".

In scientific forestry, natural forests with many kinds of trees were cut down and replaced by **plantations** of one type of tree, planted in straight rows. Forest officials planned how much to cut and how much to replant.

The **Forest Act was amended in 1878 and 1927**. The 1878 Act divided forests into three categories:

- **Reserved forests** (the best): villagers could not take anything from them, even for their own use.
- **Protected forests**.
- **Village forests**.

Effects on people: Villagers needed forests for fuelwood, fodder, fruits, roots, herbs, bamboo for fences and baskets, and the **mahua** tree for oil and cooking. Now cutting wood, grazing cattle, collecting fruits, hunting and fishing became illegal. People were forced to steal wood; forest guards harassed them and demanded bribes.

Shifting cultivation (also called **swidden** agriculture; known locally as **lading** in South East Asia, **milpa** in Central America, **chitemene or tavy** in Africa, **chena** in Sri Lanka, **dhya, penda, bewar, nevad, jhum, podu, khandad and kumri** in India)

was banned. Parts of the forest are cut and burnt in rotation; seeds are sown in the ashes after the first monsoon rains. The British said it made it hard to grow timber and risked forest fires, and it was hard to tax.

Hunting: Earlier, hunting by forest dwellers was banned, while hunting big game became a sport for rulers and the British. The British gave rewards for killing tigers, wolves and other animals as "dangerous". Over **80,000 tigers, 1,50,000 leopards and 2,00,000 wolves** were killed for reward between 1875 and 1925.

New trades and work: some groups lost their livelihood; others, like the **Banjaras** (graziers) and the **Santhals and Oraons** of Jharkhand and the Gonds of Chhattisgarh, were recruited to work on tea plantations in Assam on very low wages and could not easily return home.

Rebellion in the forest: Bastar

Bastar is located in the southernmost part of **Chhattisgarh**, bordering Andhra Pradesh, Odisha and Maharashtra. The **Indrawati river** flows across it from east to west. Communities include Maria and Muria Gonds, Dhurwas, Bhatras and Halbas.

When the colonial government proposed to reserve **two-thirds** of the forest in **1905**, stop shifting cultivation, hunting and collection of forest produce, people were angry. Some villages were allowed to stay in reserved forests only if they worked free for the forest department (**forest villages**). After famines in 1899–1900 and 1907–08, people rebelled in **1910**. Leaders included **Gunda Dhur** of village Nethanar. Bazaars were looted, houses of officials and traders burnt. The British sent troops and crushed the rebellion in three months, but **work on reservation was suspended** and the area to be reserved was reduced to roughly half.

Forest transformations in Java

Java in Indonesia was colonised by the **Dutch**, who also started forest management there. The **Kalang** people were skilled forest cutters and shifting cultivators; in 1755 they were divided between the two kingdoms of Java. The Dutch needed Javan timber to build ships.

- In the 19th century the Dutch enacted forest laws restricting villagers' access.
- They imposed rents on land being cultivated in the forest and then exempted some villages if they collectively provided free labour and buffaloes for cutting and transporting timber. This was called the **blandongdiensten** system.
- Later, villagers were given small wages but their right to cultivate forest land was restricted.

Samin's challenge: Around **1890**, **Surontiko Samin** of Randublatung village (a teak forest village) began questioning state ownership of the forest, arguing that the state had not created the wind, water, earth and wood. By 1907, about **3,000 families** followed his ideas; some lay down on their land when surveyors came, others refused to pay taxes or fines.

World Wars: the Dutch followed a "**scorched earth**" policy, destroying sawmills and burning huge piles of teak logs so they would not fall into Japanese hands. The Japanese then exploited the forests recklessly.

WHO RULED WHERE?

Bastar (India) was under the **British**; Java (Indonesia) was under the **Dutch**. Keep the colonisers and the leaders (Gunda Dhur vs Surontiko Samin) correct.

BOARD FAVOURITE

"Discuss how changes in forest management in the colonial period affected shifting cultivators, nomadic communities, firms trading in timber, plantation owners and kings/British officials hunting" is a standard 5-mark question. Write one effect for each group.

Quick recap

- Causes of deforestation: expanding cultivation, railways (sleepers), shipbuilding, plantations.
- Dietrich Brandis: Indian Forest Service 1864, Forest Act 1865; Act amended 1878 (reserved, protected, village) and 1927.
- Shifting cultivation was banned; forest people lost rights and were harassed.
- Bastar rebellion 1910 (Gunda Dhur) partly succeeded.
- Java: Dutch forest laws, blandongdiensten system, Samin movement.

Practice questions

1. Who was the first Inspector General of Forests in India?
   (a) Surontiko Samin (b) Dietrich Brandis (c) Gunda Dhur (d) Lord Dalhousie
2. The Imperial Forest Research Institute was set up at Dehradun in
   (a) 1864 (b) 1878 (c) 1906 (d) 1927
3. Under the Forest Act of 1878, the forests from which villagers could take nothing were called
   (a) reserved forests (b) protected forests (c) village forests (d) plantation forests
4. Which leader is associated with the Bastar rebellion of 1910?
   (a) Birsa Munda (b) Surontiko Samin (c) Alluri Sitarama Raju (d) Gunda Dhur
5. The blandongdiensten system in Java required villagers to
   (a) pay double taxes (b) move to towns (c) provide free labour and buffaloes for cutting and transporting timber (d) grow only teak
6. Through which state does the Indrawati river flow in the Bastar region?
   (a) Odisha (b) Chhattisgarh (c) Jharkhand (d) Madhya Pradesh
7. Why did the British need sleepers from Indian forests?
   (a) To build ships for the Royal Navy (b) To make furniture for officials (c) To fuel factories in England (d) To hold railway tracks together
8. Why did the colonial government ban shifting cultivation? How did forest laws affect the lives of forest dwellers?
9. Explain the role of railways in the expansion of deforestation in colonial India.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. a 4. d 5. c 6. b 7. d 8. see notes 9. see notes